

Factors Affecting User Experience

Formative Activity

Read Gu et al (2023) and discuss whether you agree with the authors that their findings can improve the accuracy of subjective evaluation.

Gu et al conduct an interesting experiment but draw a conclusion which is flawed. The main concern is not that their methodology improves subjective evaluation but their study simply highlights the issue that is participants are asked to evaluate aspects of a system without sufficient knowledge, they will default to the known or superficial.

It is simply common sense that if users are asked about the functionality of a website (or anything else) on first use, they will only have a superficial knowledge base to draw on. The so-called 'Halo effect' is a fallacy and masks the flawed questioning. Karen (2025) discusses the merits of expert authority and the impact on assessment. This highlights the importance of gaining knowledge in a domain before having the authority to hold an opinion on that domain. This emphasises the fact that at the beginning of the process, subjects were asked of an opinion regarding functionality when their knowledge of functionality was not sufficient to allow an authoritative response.

References

Gu, Q., Tang, W., Xue, C. (2023). The Effect of Time Lapse on the Halo Effect in the Subjective Evaluation of Digital Interfaces. In: Marcus, A., Rosenzweig, E., Soares, M.M. (eds) Design, User Experience, and Usability. HCI 2023. Lecture Notes in Computer Science, vol 14032. Springer, Cham. https://doi-org.uniessexlib.idm.oclc.org/10.1007/978-3-031-35702-2_12

Keren, A. (2025). Expert Authority and Its Assessment. *Social Epistemology*, 1–14. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02691728.2025.2472780>